

we'd like to see more saving options compared to software such as Adobe Illustrator. Its XML based format means that you can access your work from other compliant software.

Svg- edit

Written in Javascript, SVG- edit is meant to quickly edit web pages online. What caught our attention is that it is available online and there is no fuss about downloading and installing. It works on any of the commonly used web browsers including Firefox, Chrome, Safari, Internet Explorer and Opera.

Skencil

The makers of Skencil take pride in the fact that the software was created almost entirely in the Python language with a little part in C and so supposedly combining the power and flexibility of Python with the speed of C. The more advanced features available in the editor are gradient fills, clip masks, text along a path, blend groups and converting text to curves, Skencil is a Linux based software.

Our pick- Inkscape

Although it doesn't match up to the features of Illustrator, we find that it is the most viable alternative for the monetarily challenged. It's still pretty powerful though and its numerous tools and features are more than satisfactorily presented in its user interface. Although we aren't fully convinced about the usefulness of its 3D boxes tool, but who knows what creativity can unlock! The almost overwhelming number of Filters and Extensions has got us bittersweet because of the time we spent filtering them. The application starts up really quickly but the lag afterwards has really got us down.

What sets it apart is that its native format is the SVG standard and while it supports many advanced SVG features like cloning, markers and alpha blending, it skimps out on some others like filter effects, SVG fonts and animations. That said, it's really easy to perform actions like editing nodes, tracing bitmaps and even complex path operations. But what caught our eye was the impressive command line interface that you can use for exporting, format conversions and a variety of other tasks.

Did we mention we love the user interface? This usability is further enhanced by an excellent website that houses all the tutorials you'll ever need to use Inkscape.